

Zero to Launch: The < \$1,000 Low-Code SaaS Starter

Building a SaaS used to cost thousands in dev time. With a combination of AI and low-code tools, you can **validate, build, and launch for under \$1,000 in weeks.**

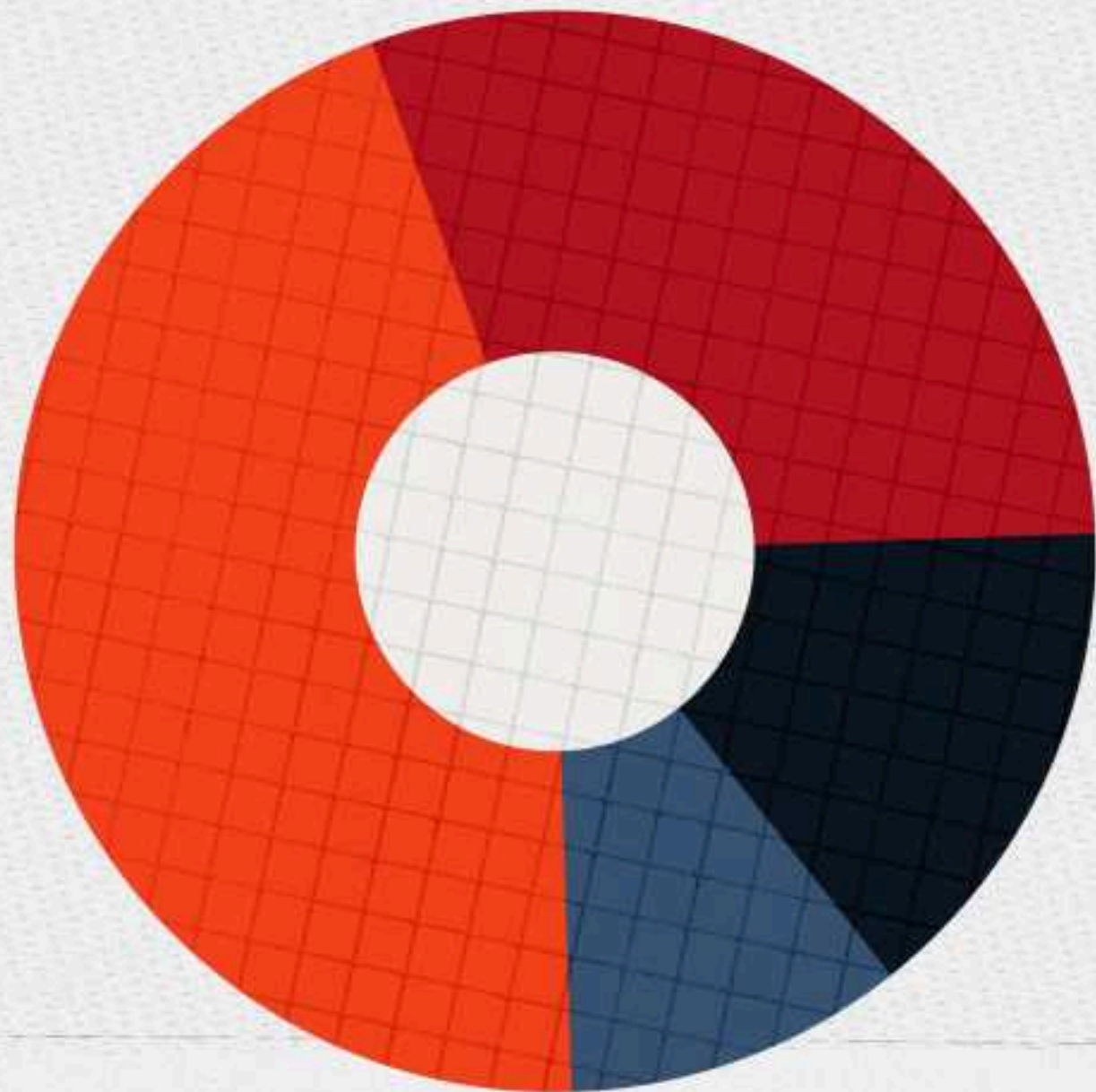
SMART MONEY ALLOCATION

Where your limited funds should go:

45%

Tech stack + tooling
(hosting, builder, backend logic)

Tip: Focus on functionality, not features. You can ship faster with fewer moving parts.



30%

Marketing & early traction

15%

Legal basics + templates

10%

Contingency buffer

ESSENTIAL TOOLS

Save ~\$5,000+ annually by swapping out these tools:

FUNCTION	PREMIUM TOOL	FREE/LOW-COST ALTERNATIVE
App Builder	Webflow + Dev Team (\$500+)	Glide, Softr, Bubble (Free/low-tier)
Backend/Logic	Firebase + API Dev (\$200/mo)	Xano (Free tier), Airtable (Free), Zapier (Starter)
Website	Framer (\$25/mo)	Carrd.co (\$9/yr)
Email Marketing	ConvertKit (\$29/mo)	Beehiiv (Free tier)
Project Mgmt	ClickUp (\$9/mo)	Notion (Free tier)
Analytics	Amplitude (\$45/mo)	Plausible.io (\$9/mo)
Copywriting	Jasper.ai (\$49/mo)	ChatGPT (Free), Copy.ai (Free tier)
UI Design	Figma Pro (\$12/mo)	Figma (Free), Canva

QUICK-WIN TACTICS

- **Waitlist countdown:** Add urgency by showing signup targets publicly
- **Build in public:** Share weekly updates and metrics on Twitter/LinkedIn
- **Leverage AI:** Use ChatGPT to generate 50 onboarding email variations to A/B test
- **Offer a founding member deal:** Discounted pricing for first 25 users + perks

ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Sketch your idea with Figma or pen + paper
- ☐ Create a waitlist page with Carrd or Softr
- ☐ Share in 3 relevant communities
- ☐ Start building your MVP with Bubble or Glide
- ☐ Post your journey on Twitter and collect feedback

THE 3-STEP LAUNCH

STEP 1: VALIDATION (\$0)

- Use Glide or Carrd to create a landing page with a waitlist
- Share in 3 communities (IndieHackers, Twitter, niche Discords)
- Run a short survey to validate interest and collect pain points
- **Goal:** 100 signups = validated need

STEP 2: BUILD (Up to \$400)

- Build your MVP using Bubble, Glide, or Softr with Airtable/Xano backend
- Use ChatGPT to write onboarding emails and feature copy
- Connect payments via Stripe
- Set up analytics with Plausible.io

STEP 3: LAUNCH (\$100–\$300)

- Share early access invite to your waitlist
- Post your build journey on Twitter + IndieHackers
- Offer a Founding Plan with lifetime pricing or bonuses
- Launch on Product Hunt or Betalist